

WILD CARD
TVK chief Vijay at a party meet in Chengalpattu, Tamil Nadu, Jan. 25

PTI

more headroom to saffron's actual ally.

That tentative axis has not survived the sustained scrutiny Vijay is facing on Karur, including the Supreme Court-ordered CBI probe. Perhaps it's reflected rancour, perhaps a growing sense that he may profit more in a solo sortie. Either way, he's now accusing the AIADMK of betraying legacy by hitching its wagon to a force 'incompatible with Tamil Nadu'—narrowing the space for future accommodation. In response, the AIADMK leadership has been silent, but its IT wing has mounted aggressive salvos on Vijay, questioning his finances, his political credibility and his conduct on Karur.

There are no formal opinion polls yet, but political trackers and informal surveys

Takeaways

- **SC-ordered CBI probe on Karur stampede, censor heat on his film *Jana Nayagan* spike Vijay's profile**
- **The actor turns hostile toward the AIADMK, signals going solo amid reports of good vote share potential**

circulating within parties suggest a more decent take-home for the TVK than for past solo voyagers. Younger voters and first-timers, in particular, could be drawn to his outsider appeal. Even a modestly good vote share could matter. Prior reckoning had put the DMK as the vulnerable party, now the AIADMK's base is not safe either. The TVK may not need to win many seats to reshape the contest. Its presence could create several triangular fights, complicating calculations for both the Dravidian majors.

Since there's nothing like turbulence on the cultural front to create some good political capital in Tamil Nadu, the prolonged delays Vijay's *Jana Nayagan* has run into with the Central Board of Film Certification could sharpen the script for him further. Legal battles over it eventually reached the Supreme Court, and TVK supporters are citing it as more evidence of institutional arm-twisting. In short, the pressure cooker is building up to the 'whistle' moment. ■